



dominate T20s and then change themselves according to the Test format. That only happens when you have a deep understanding of the format. You have to use the net sessions in between according to the demands of the format," the middle-order batter says.

He also underlined the importance of the Indian domestic system, which "tests the player in every way", in shaping all-format cricketers.

The India dream?

For most cricketers, wearing the Indian jersey is the ultimate dream. Their first steps with the ball in hand, or the first tap of the bat on the ground, begin with the hope of one day winning a game for the country.

Through the ups and downs the sport inevitably brings, the glimmer

of hope of donning the jersey again is often what keeps them going.

Patidar, however, appears cut from a different cloth.

"I have never really thought of playing for the country. My focus has been on controlling the controllables. The rest is not in my hands. Even when I make runs, and I don't get picked, I have no complaints. I am satisfied wherever I am," the batter says.

This maturity in thought, too, came with age, he explains.

"When you're young, everyone wants to know why they weren't picked for the team. But after a while, it is important to see what is necessary for you. Cricket is a part of life, but it is not life in its entirety. For me, I should bat well and score runs for my team. The rest I have no control over," he adds.

Stellar across formats: In the 2021-22 Ranji Trophy, Rajat Patidar hit 85 in the quarterfinal against Punjab, 7 and 79 in the semifinal, and 122 and 30 not out in the final against Mumbai as Madhya Pradesh won the tournament for the first time. K. MURALI KUMAR

In an era characterised by cut-throat competition and constant pressure, Patidar offers a refreshing, more measured perspective on cricket and life. He might be a Ranji Trophy champion, an IPL-winning captain and a cricketer who has represented India in the toughest format of the game. But he does not mind admitting that he is just another human being juggling priorities and trying to remain content.

(Stats as of May 16)

What's your biggest non-sports dream?

A big family and a very nice house, that's it

A song that you go back to regularly?

'90s Bollywood music and sometimes even Kishore Kumar

EMMANUEL YOGINI

